Lech Lecha 5784

In the second pasuk of the פרשה, it says וְאֶעֶשְׂךָ לְגוֹי גָּדוֹל וַאֲבָרֶכְךָ וַאֲגַדְּלָה שְׁמֶךָ וְהְיֵה בְּרָכָה. In רש"י, after his first pshat, he explains that וְאֶעֶשְׂךָ לְגוֹי גָּדוֹל refers to what we say in שמונה עשרה: אֱלֹקֵי אַבְרָהָם, אֱלֹקֵי יִצְחָק, and וֵאלֹקֵי יַעֲקֹב refers to וַאֲגַדְּלָה שְׁמֶךָ refers to וַאֲבָרֶכְךָ. "כֻּלָּן יִהְיוּ חוֹתְמִין בְּכֻלָּן" - the bracha could have ended by saying מָגֵן אַבְרָהָם יִצְחָק וְיַעֲקֹב, "תַּלְמוּד לוֹמַר וְהְיֵה בְּרָכָה, בְּךָ חוֹתְמִין וְלֹא בָהֶם" - the bracha of שמונה עשרה ends with מָגֵן אַבְרָהָם.

This teaches us that the aspect of גמילות חסדים, represented by אברהם אבינו, is the foundation of all three messages.

I want to share a small מעשה that arrived today. I'm recording this during the first week of the war in ארץ ישראל. This story comes from the Boehm family: I spoke last night with a חיילת who is currently on a base in the north. She mentioned that there are many more soldiers there than usual, and they don't have enough mattresses. Someone generously donated a bunch of new mattresses for the combat soldiers, and though the soldiers are very grateful, they're not removing the plastic covering. They plan to donate these mattresses to families in the south who will need them once, בעזרת השם, the war is behind us. מי כעמך ישראל - what an incredible people.

The ספר אהל תורה quoted in מעינה של תורה, comments on וְהְיֵה בְּרָכָה and the idea that בְּךָ חוֹתְמִין וְלֹא בָהֶם. The משנה teaches us (Avos 1:2): עַל שְׁלשָׁה דְבָרִים הָעוֹלָם עוֹמֵד, עַל הַתּוֹרָה וְעַל הָעֲבוֹדָה וְעַל גְּמִילוּת חֲסָדִים. Each of these corresponding to one of the אבות: אברהם represents גמילות חסדים, יצחק represents עבודה, since he offered himself as a קרבן; and יעקב represents תורה, as the אִישׁ תָּם יֹשֵׁב אֹהָלִים. In the later generations, in which we are now participating, preceding the coming of משיח, the תורה tells us that תורה and עבודה will not be what they once were - and indeed, we see this. Though we may not compare to the previous generations, the גאולה will ultimately come in the merit of גמילות חסדים, as the pasuk in ישעיה says (1:27), צִיּוֹן בְּמִשְׁפָּט תִּפָּדֶה וְשָׁבֶיהָ בִּצְדָקָה. That's what רש"י means when he says בְּךָ חוֹתְמִין, he means "we will end with you" - in the חותמה of גלות, (at the end of the גלות) It will only be בְּךָ - in merit of the גמילות חסדים of אברהם אבינו, and that will make up for נבוך, our failures in תורה and עבודה.

By the way, we still see people being מוסר נפש for תורה and עבודה today. Though we don't measure up to the previous generations, there are those who are doing their best. We must strive to participate in תורה, עבודה, and גמילות חסדים, in any way we can because these three things are the שלושה עמודי העולם, they keep the world in existence. Our existence in the world is tied with a קשר to הקדוש ברוך הוא.

I recently came across a dvar torah from רבי יצחק טוביה וייס, the former אב בית דין in ירושלים. It's a remarkable insight I'd like to share. If you open a תהילים and look at פרק קמ"ה, תְּהִלָּה לְדָוִד, known as אַשְׁרֵי, you'll notice that each pasuk contains a ו, a ו החיבור - a connecting ו, that connects the first half of the pasuk to the second half, except for one pasuk: קָרוֹב ה' לְכָל קֹרְאָיו לְכֹל אֲשֶׁר יִקְרָאֻהוּ בֶּאֱמֶת. This unique pasuk has no ו connecting the two halves. רבי וייס explains that the ו החיבור in each pasuk is a symbol of the deep bond between כלל ישראל and הקדוש ברוך הוא. pasuk of קָרוֹב ה' לְכָל קֹרְאָיו represents an intrinsic חיבור that doesn't need a ו - it stands alone as a pasuk of pure connection.

https://youtu.be/yLyKkRKOxJc

Take a moment to look at תְּהִלָּה לְדָוִד and notice the ו in each pasuk. I've been saying אַשְׁרֵי all these years and never saw this! It's amazing how Hashem sometimes shows you something you've been doing all your life that you've never fully appreciated.

May we recognize our profound connection to הקדוש ברוך הוא, and may our love for כלל ישראל be strong as we daven. May our enemies be defeated, may we find victory in a way that reflects the values of תורה, and may we succeed not by our own might, but by the help of Hashem's hand, with עזרת השם יתברך. May we not only survive, but be victorious.

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